a three-week practice



Back *to You*

Twenty-one short practices to see your pattern, understand where it came from, and choose differently, in love, at work and with yourself.

21 days	3 weeks	7 archetype lenses
TEN TO FIFTEEN MINUTES EACH	LOOK · LISTEN · CHOOSE	ON THE DAYS THEY MATTER

before you begin

How this works

This isn't a course. There's nothing to memorize and nothing to pass. It's twenty-one short practices, ten to fifteen minutes a day, that help you see the loop you keep living, understand why it started, and step out of it on purpose.

Each day gives you a small exercise, often with something to try out in your real life, a journal question, a question for tonight, and lined space. Messy handwriting is welcome. Some days refer back to earlier pages, so keep everything together. Fell behind? Just continue with the next day. A day isn't relevant to your life? Skip it, no guilt. What counts is noticing.

By your thirties and forties, patterns are rarely about one area. The reflex that makes you go quiet with a partner is the one that keeps you quiet in a meeting and at your mother's table. So the practices here cover all of it: love, work, family, money, and the way you talk to yourself.

WEEK 1 · DAYS 1–7

Look

First you have to see the loop. This week you simply watch your own life like a friendly researcher: in love, at work, with family. No fixing yet. Notice, and write it down.

WEEK 2 · DAYS 8–14

Listen

Every pattern started as a good idea. This week you listen for the need underneath yours, the rules you inherited, and the pressures of this particular decade, and you count what the old way costs.

WEEK 3 · DAYS 15–21

Choose

Understanding alone changes nothing. This week you test small, safe changes in real life, and you finish by writing the code you'll live by.

Your archetypes come along

Most women carry several of the seven archetypes, each with a gift and a shadow. On five of the days you'll see an **archetype lens**: seven quick hints, one per archetype. Start with yours, glance at the others, and if your own experience is different, your experience wins.

- The Romantic
- The Oracle
- The Strategist
- The Trailblazer
- The Sovereign
- The Nurturer
- The Dreamer

A GENTLE NOTE

Some of these days may bring up old hurt. Go at your own pace. If something feels too heavy to hold alone, that's a good reason to talk to a therapist or someone you trust, not a sign you're doing it wrong.

1

WEEK 1 · DAYS 1 TO 7

Look

First you have to see the loop. This week you simply watch your own life like a friendly researcher: in love, at work, with family. No fixing yet. Notice, and write it down.

WEEK 1 · LOOK · DAY 1

The timeline

See your life from a little distance.

Draw a line across the notes space: one end is 20, the other is today. Above the line, mark five moments when you felt most like yourself; below it, five when you felt least like yourself. Love, work, friends, family, body: everything counts. Add one word to each mark. Don't analyze yet. Just look at the shape.

JOURNAL

What do the “most like me” moments have in common?

TONIGHT

Which mark surprised you?

WEEK 1 · LOOK · DAY 2

Jolts

Catch the moments your pattern switches on.

Today, whenever something gives you a jolt, a small flash of hurt, anger, worry or shame, jot it down in four parts: the moment, the feeling, the urge, the action. It can be tiny: a colleague's tone, your mother asking about grandchildren, a message marked “seen” with no reply. Aim for four. A quiet day? Log four from this past week.

JOURNAL

Which jolts were about love, which about work, which about you? Is there a theme?

TONIGHT

Which jolt did you almost not write down?

WEEK 1 · LOOK · DAY 3

Body first

Learn the signal that arrives before the story.

Pick two jolts from yesterday. Close your eyes and replay each for fifteen seconds, scanning from jaw to stomach. What tightened, dropped, heated up or went numb? Write one line per jolt. Try to catch one live today. By tonight, name your two most reliable body signals. That's your early-warning system.

ARCHETYPE LENS · COMMON BODY SIGNALS

Romantic	A hollow feeling in the chest when warmth isn't returned.
Oracle	A heaviness, then the urge to go far away inside.
Strategist	A busy head, and a body you barely notice.
Trailblazer	Shoulders up, jaw set, ready to handle it alone.
Sovereign	A tight grip, in the hands or the gut, when things slip.
Nurturer	A bone-deep tiredness you push straight past.
Dreamer	A stillness, like holding your breath and waiting.

JOURNAL

What is your body's first sign that you're slipping into your pattern?

TONIGHT

Did you notice a signal today before you reacted, or after?

WEEK 1 · LOOK · DAY 4

Fact or story?

Separate what happened from what you made it mean.

Choose three jolts. For each, write two lines. First the fact, as a camera would record it: “My manager moved our meeting to Friday.” Then the story you told yourself: “She doesn't rate me. I'm about to be sidelined.” See how much extra the story invents, and how quickly it shows up. At the bottom, write your story as one headline, like “I'm on my own” or “I'm too much.”

JOURNAL

How old is that headline? When do you first remember believing it?

TONIGHT

How many times did the headline run today?

WEEK 1 · LOOK · DAY 5

The reflex

Name what you do once the story starts.

Everyone has a reflex: the move you make when the headline runs. Look at the “action” part of your jolt log. Write your two most common moves in precise, unflattering detail. Not “I withdraw” but “I answer in one word and suddenly have a lot of work.” Under each, write what it's trying to get for you, and what it actually gets.

ARCHETYPE LENS · TYPICAL REFLEXES

Romantic	Reaching: more contact, more effort, more proof you're wanted.
Oracle	Vanishing inward, or deciding it all happened for a reason.
Strategist	Researching, replaying, building the airtight case.
Trailblazer	“I'll handle it myself,” and a closed door.
Sovereign	Taking the wheel, or going cool and correct.
Nurturer	Saying yes, then looking after everyone's feelings except yours.
Dreamer	Going along, going quiet, waiting it out.

JOURNAL

What is your reflex protecting you from?

TONIGHT

Did you catch the reflex today? What came right before it?

WEEK 1 · LOOK · DAY 6

Energy audit

Notice who and what fills you up or drains you.

Make two columns: Fills me and Drains me. List everyone you spent time with this week and everything you did: work tasks, scrolling, family calls, the gym, the friend who only calls to vent. Be honest; nobody will read this. Then star anything in the drain column that you agreed to because of your reflex.

JOURNAL

What's one thing in the drain column you keep choosing, and why?

TONIGHT

Where did your energy go today?

WEEK 1 · LOOK · DAY 7

Your loop

Put the week together into one picture.

Draw your loop as a circle with five stops: the jolt (Day 2), the body signal (Day 3), the headline (Day 4), the reflex (Day 5), and the result, meaning what usually happens next. Add an arrow from the result back to the jolt, because the result often sets up the next round. Hold it up against your timeline from Day 1. Then write: “This is my loop. Now I can see it.”

JOURNAL

Where in the loop could you most easily step out?

TONIGHT

What was it like to observe yourself for a whole week without criticism?

2

WEEK 2 · DAYS 8 TO 14

Listen

Every pattern started as a good idea. This week you listen for the need underneath yours, the rules you inherited, and the pressures of this particular decade, and you count what the old way costs.

WEEK 2 · LISTEN · DAY 8

What it's guarding

Find the need under the reflex.

Every reflex is a bodyguard for a need: to feel safe, wanted, respected, capable, free, needed or seen. Look at your two reflexes from Day 5. For each, finish the sentence "I do this because I need to feel…" Keep going past the first answer. The second or third is usually the true one.

ARCHETYPE LENS · THE NEED EACH ARCHETYPE'S REFLEX GUARDS

Romantic	To feel wanted, steadily.
Oracle	To be understood without having to explain.
Strategist	To feel safe through understanding.
Trailblazer	To stay free and whole.
Sovereign	To feel secure and respected.
Nurturer	To feel valued, and to belong.
Dreamer	To feel chosen and accepted.

JOURNAL

Which need have you been meeting in a way that doesn't quite work?

TONIGHT

When did you feel that need today?

WEEK 2 · LISTEN · DAY 9

Inherited rules

Find the rules you never chose.

Write down every rule you absorbed growing up about three things: love, money, and what a woman should be. “Don't need anyone.” “Money causes fights.” “Good girls don't make a fuss.” “Rest is earned.” Next to each, write who taught it to you, in words or by example. Then mark each one: keep, rewrite, or retire.

JOURNAL

Which rule is running your life the most right now?

TONIGHT

Where did you obey an old rule today?

WEEK 2 · LISTEN · DAY 10

When it made sense

Honor the strategy before you change it.

Your pattern was never a mistake. At some point it was the smartest thing you could do. Write about the first time you remember using your reflex: how old you were, what was going on, what it protected you from. Then write one line of thanks to the younger you who figured it out.

ARCHETYPE LENS · WHERE EACH ARCHETYPE'S STRATEGY OFTEN BEGINS

Romantic	Love that came and went, so you learned to hold on.
Oracle	A home where feelings went unspoken, so you learned to sense them.
Strategist	Unpredictability, so you learned to think ahead.
Trailblazer	Help that came with strings, so you learned to need nothing.
Sovereign	Chaos, so you learned to take charge.
Nurturer	A parent who needed looking after, so you learned to give.
Dreamer	Being corrected or overruled, so you learned to wait.

JOURNAL

What did your pattern get right, back then?

TONIGHT

Where did something today feel like an old situation?

WEEK 2 · LISTEN · DAY 11

The shoulds of this decade

Separate your timeline from everyone else's.

List every “should” you feel about this stage of life: married by, kids by, house by, earning this much by, body like this, career at that level. Write fast. Next to each, write whose voice it is: a parent, friends, your feed, an ex, a magazine from years ago. Circle the ones that are truly yours. Cross out at least one that isn't.

JOURNAL

If nobody were watching, what would you want this decade to be about?

TONIGHT

Which “should” showed up today?

WEEK 2 · LISTEN · DAY 12

The price tag

Count what the pattern costs.

Your loop has costs, and most stay invisible because you pay them in small amounts. Write what it has cost you in four areas: love, work, money and health. Be specific: the relationship you stayed in a year too long, the raise you never asked for, the sleep you lost, the friendship that faded. No blame. Just the bill.

JOURNAL

Which cost hurts most to write down?

TONIGHT

What would a week without paying it look like?

WEEK 2 · LISTEN · DAY 13

A letter back in time

Talk to the woman who started the loop.

Write a letter to yourself at 25, or whatever age feels right. Tell her what you know now about her pattern, what it was trying to do for her, and what you wish she had known. Be as kind as you'd be to a younger friend. End with one piece of advice she could actually use.

JOURNAL

What would she want to tell you back?

TONIGHT

How did it feel to be kind to her?

WEEK 2 · LISTEN · DAY 14

Wants, unedited

Let yourself want without asking permission.

Set a timer for ten minutes and write twenty things you want, big and small, sensible and not: a partner who plans the dates, a raise, a garden, to stop apologizing, a month by the sea. Don't stop to judge. When the timer ends, circle the three that make your chest feel lighter. They are your direction for next week.

JOURNAL

Which want did you almost not write?

TONIGHT

What would move one of the three forward by an inch?

3

WEEK 3 · DAYS 15 TO 21

Choose

Understanding alone changes nothing. This week you test small, safe changes in real life, and you finish by writing the code you'll live by.

WEEK 3 · CHOOSE · DAY 15

One clear ask

Ask for one thing, plainly.

Take one of your circled wants and make one direct ask today. Small is perfect: “Can you call me tonight?” “I'd like to lead the next project.” “Can you pick up the kids on Thursday?” One sentence, no apology, no long explanation. Write what you asked, how you felt beforehand, and what happened.

JOURNAL

What did your reflex want to do instead of asking?

TONIGHT

How did it feel to hear your own voice ask?

WEEK 3 · CHOOSE · DAY 16

Ten minutes

Put space between the jolt and the reflex.

Today, when a jolt hits, wait ten minutes before you respond. Set a timer if you need one. Breathe low and slow, feel your feet on the floor, name the feeling in one word. When the time is up, choose your response on purpose. It may be the same as your reflex, and that's fine. What matters is that you chose it.

JOURNAL

What happened in your body during those ten minutes?

TONIGHT

Did the pause change what you did?

WEEK 3 · CHOOSE · DAY 17

The kind no

Protect your energy without a fight.

Go back to your energy audit from Day 6. Pick one thing in the drain column and say no to it today, or to the next request like it. Keep it short and kind: “I can't this time.” “That doesn't work for me.” No excuse, no backstory. Notice the urge to explain, and let it pass.

JOURNAL

What did you fear would happen if you said no?

TONIGHT

What actually happened?

WEEK 3 · CHOOSE · DAY 18

The opposite move

Run one small experiment against your reflex.

Pick one moment today where your reflex usually takes over, and do the opposite on purpose, in a small, safe way. It will feel awkward. Awkward is how new feels. Write what you did and what happened next.

ARCHETYPE LENS · THE OPPOSITE MOVE FOR EACH ARCHETYPE

Romantic	Skip the follow-up text. Enjoy an evening that's just yours.
Oracle	Say the plain thing out loud, in one sentence.
Strategist	Send the unedited message. Feel first, figure out later.
Trailblazer	Ask for help with something you could do yourself.
Sovereign	Let someone else decide, and don't correct it.
Nurturer	Let others handle their own feelings. Rest.
Dreamer	State your preference first, before anyone else does.

JOURNAL

What surprised you about doing the opposite?

TONIGHT

Would you try it again? Where?

WEEK 3 · CHOOSE · DAY 19

Receive

Let something in without deflecting it.

Today, receive one thing fully: a compliment, an offer of help, a gift, a kind word. Don't wave it off, explain it away or rush to pay it back. Say “thank you” and stop there. If nothing comes your way, ask a friend to tell you one thing she appreciates about you, and receive that.

JOURNAL

Why is receiving hard for you?

TONIGHT

What did you receive today, and how did it land?

Repair

Mend one moment where the old pattern won.

Choose a recent moment when your reflex hurt someone, maybe yourself. Write a short repair: what happened, what was going on underneath for you, what you're sorry for, and what you'll try next time. If it's safe and right, have the conversation. If not, read it aloud to yourself. Patterns loosen their grip not when you stop slipping, but when you keep coming back.

JOURNAL

Who, including you, is owed a repair?

TONIGHT

How did it feel to own it without beating yourself up?

Your code

Write the standard you'll live by from here.

Reread every page from the last twenty days. Then fill this one in, slowly, in your own words. This is not a list of resolutions. It's a description of the woman you've been practicing being. Sign it. Date it. Keep it somewhere you'll see it.

What I do now

Describe five things you now do differently. For example: “I ask directly.” “I wait ten minutes before answering anything that stings.”

What I'm retiring

The reflexes I'm done with, named plainly. For example: “I no longer say yes when I'm exhausted.”

What I look for in the people close to me

How they treat me when I'm direct, when I say no, when I let them help. Not how it looks from outside.

What I do when I slip

Because I will. My plan for coming back without beating myself up.

Signed _____ Date _____

after day 21

Where to go from here

Three weeks is enough to see a pattern and start loosening it. It isn't enough to make the new way automatic. That takes ordinary repetition, mostly on days when nothing dramatic is happening.

Pick one practice to keep for the next month, the one that helped most. For many women it's the ten-minute pause from Day 16; for others it's the clear ask, or the kind no. Put your code from Day 21 somewhere you'll see it every morning: inside a cupboard door, as your phone's lock screen, folded in your wallet.

Expect the old loop to return when life gets loud: a new relationship, a tough review, a holiday with family, a name from the past on your screen late at night. That isn't failure. It's the loop doing what loops do. Make a quick repair the way you did on Day 20, and carry on from where you are. Later, perhaps in the spring or after a big change, take the three weeks again with a clean copy. You'll be writing as a slightly different woman, and the pages will show it.

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a last word

Nothing about you needed fixing

The pattern you've been watching was a clever answer to an old question: how do I stay safe, wanted, respected, free? It did its job. You've simply outgrown the version of the answer you learned first. Your gifts were always there and they're staying. What changes is who's driving.

So take what you've found back into your love life, your work and your home. Notice the jolt. Feel the signal. Name the need. Then do the thing that fits the woman you are now, not the girl who first learned the loop.

TO KEEP

I know my loop. I know my need. I choose.